

Analysis of Type 1 A&E Demand, Breaches and 4-Hour Performance in NHS England (Apr 2023 – Mar 2025)

1 Background & Context

Accident & Emergency (A&E) performance remains a critical operational and political priority for NHS England. The national 4-hour standard requires at least 95% of patients attending Type 1 A&E departments to be admitted, transferred or discharged within four hours.

In recent years, sustained increases in demand, seasonal winter pressures, workforce constraints and delayed patient flow have contributed to widespread under-performance against this standard.

This case study analyses national Type 1 A&E data across a two-year period to understand trends in demand, breach volumes and performance, with a particular focus on winter pressure impacts.

2 Objective of the Analysis

The objective of this analysis was to:

- Examine trends in Type 1 A&E attendances and breach volumes
- Assess performance against the NHS 95% four-hour standard
- Identify seasonal (winter) pressure patterns
- Present findings in an executive-level dashboard suitable for operational and strategic decision-making

3 Data & Methodology

Data source

Monthly A&E Attendances and Emergency Admissions data published by NHS England.

Scope

- Geography: **England**
- Service type: **Type 1 A&E (Major Emergency Departments)**
- Period: **April 2023 – March 2025**

Tools

- Tableau Desktop (Public Edition)
- Excel (data reshaping)

Methodology

The dataset was reshaped into a long format to enable flexible aggregation by service type, metric and month.

Key measures were derived, including total attendances, attendances breaching the four-hour standard, and calculated four-hour performance percentages.

A rolling 12-month average was applied to performance metrics to distinguish underlying trends from short-term volatility.

Conditional RAG (Red/Amber/Green) thresholds were aligned to NHS performance standards to enable rapid executive interpretation.

4 Dashboard Overview

NHS England – Type 1 A&E Performance

KPI – 4-hour Performance (Latest)	KPI – Attendance (Latest)	KPI – Breaches >4h (Latest)
60.9%	1,450,686	566,995

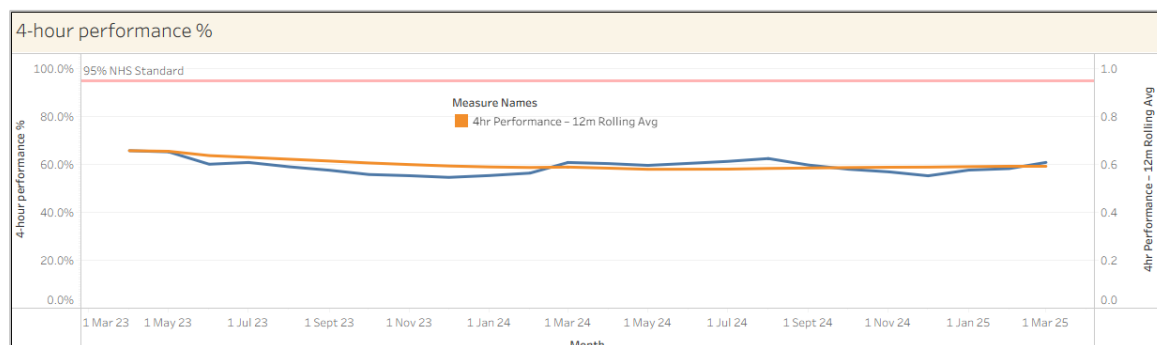
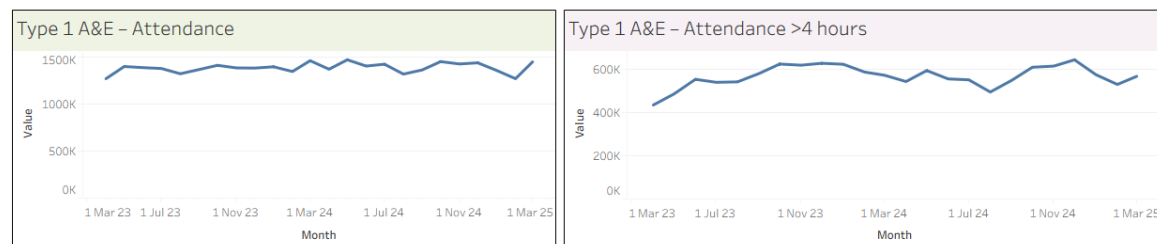


Figure 1: Executive dashboard summarising demand, pressure and performance for Type 1 A&E services in NHS England.

5 Key Findings

Demand

- Type 1 A&E attendances remained consistently high, averaging approximately 1.3–1.5 million per month.
- Demand peaks align strongly with winter months, indicating predictable seasonal pressure rather than random variation.

Breaches (>4 hours)

- Attendances breaching the four-hour standard increase sharply during winter periods.
- Breach volumes closely track overall attendance levels, suggesting system congestion rather than isolated operational failures.

Performance

- Four-hour performance remains significantly below the 95% NHS standard throughout the period.
- Performance deterioration is most pronounced during winter months, with sustained red RAG status.
- Rolling averages indicate that under-performance is structural rather than short-term.

6 Interpretation & NHS Insight

The analysis suggests that under-performance against the four-hour standard is driven primarily by sustained demand pressures and patient flow constraints within Type 1 departments.

Seasonal winter pressures exacerbate existing capacity limitations, resulting in prolonged breach periods rather than short-lived dips.

The consistency of these patterns across multiple winter cycles indicates that performance recovery is unlikely without system-wide interventions addressing bed availability, discharge pathways and community capacity.

7 Value of the Dashboard

The dashboard provides a clear, executive-level view that enables:

- Rapid identification of performance deterioration
- Separation of seasonal effects from underlying trends
- Evidence-based discussions around capacity planning and winter preparedness

8 Conclusion

This case study demonstrates how national A&E data can be transformed into actionable insight through structured analysis and clear visualisation.

By combining trend analysis, performance thresholds and seasonal context, the dashboard highlights the scale and persistence of challenges facing Type 1 A&E services, reinforcing the need for long-term system-level solutions.